BOOKS

# SHORING UP THE SHORE

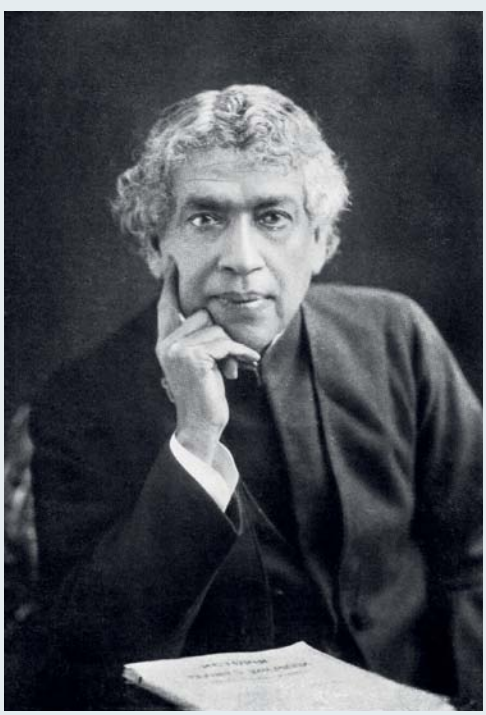
*Sejal Mehta makes science fun and accessible in her book on creatures who live between land and sea*





**This book is about** the lives and abilities of the little-known, small creatures that can be found, if looked for, in the intertidal: the stretch of ocean shore between the high and low tide levels. This boundary between the two realms of our planet—land and ocean—rolls back and forth with the tides to the tune of the moon, as much a time-setter for the creatures living there, as is day and night for us. It is a very tiny strip of the planet but is and has been the threshold for organisms crossing from one realm to the other. The peculiarities of the organisms adapted to the intertidal are fascinating, because evolution has selected them for survival in both realms, which makes them closer to science fiction than to us.

As a retired professor of marine biology, I didn't know what to expect when I took my first random dip in the book, but soon found myself reading on until I reached the end of the chapter. What fascinated me was the multi-faceted experience of having one's attention dragged hither and thither, between prose and poetry, conversations and lectures, now dealing with the predilections of the particular creature under examination, then musings of the author interspersed with resonating quotes from other authors, and much more, all told with excitement. For me, this was very different fare to what I have



BOOKS

# Down to His Science

**Kunal Ghosh's biography of J.C. Bose highlights the scientist's rigour, patriotism and uprightness**

Generations of Indians have grown up hearing the name of Jagadish Chandra Bose. While we have known he was famous in the West, there are only brief references in textbooks and newspapers that tell us that it was he and not Guglielmo Marconi who invented radio communication. The name of the Bengali scientist again popped up at the turn of the century as the world celebrated the 100th anniversary of the invention of wireless communication. Researchers were surprised to see that Bose held the first American patent on this technology, long before Marconi had used that and other inventions to communicate across distances.

*Unsung Genius: A Life of Jagadish Chandra Bose* is a hefty volume, chronicling in minute detail the experiments and life of this reclusive scientist of the 19th century. Kunal Ghosh, a former professor of aerospace engineering at the Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur, pored over hundreds of documents to write this exhaustive biography of Bose as a physicist and, later, a plant physiologist. With diagrams, photographs and formulae, he explains the experiments in radio communication to build a case for why Bose, not Marconi, should have been given the Nobel Prize.